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VOL. 6 · ST. JOHN

From Seven Votes to 573: How Kerryne James Locked Down St. John

In 2022 St. John was the closest seat in Grenada, won by the NDC by seven votes. Four years later the same two candidates met again, and the margin was 573. The NNP's share fell by less than the national swing, yet it still lost ground in almost every corner of the parish.

BY GREG HOSTEN

ST. JOHN, GRENADA

ST. JOHN, GRENADA—No constituency in Grenada was closer in 2022 than St. John. The NDC's Kerryne James defeated the NNP's Alvin DaBreo by 2,216 votes to 2,209, a margin of seven. On a night when the NDC won government by nine seats to six, St. John was the one seat that could have gone either way.

> **"A narrow defeat is an asset only if it is used. Seven votes became 573."**
>
> GREG HOSTEN

On 5th November the same two candidates met again. Ms. James took 2,540 votes to Mr. DaBreo's 1,967, with 82 for the DPM's Arley Gill and 24 for the GULP's Geoffrey Preudhomme. Seven votes became 573, and the most marginal seat in the country became a comfortable NDC hold.

THE CLOSEST SEAT IN THE COUNTRY

St. John covers Gouyave, the parish's fishing town, together with Grand Roy, Concord, Florida, Mount Granby and Clozier, and it has long been competitive. Mr. DaBreo, a former NNP member for the seat, lost it in 2022 by the smallest margin of the entire election.

A seven-vote defeat is the best possible starting point for an opposition party. It means that the seat is genuinely winnable, that the candidate is known, and that a few extra hours of canvassing in a single village could change the result. The question for the NNP was what it would do with four years.

FOUR YEARS ON, THE SAME CONTEST, A DIFFERENT RESULT

The answer lies in the numbers. Between 2022 and 2026 the NNP's vote fell by 242, from 2,209 to 1,967, while Ms. James's rose by 324, from 2,216 to 2,540. The NNP's share of the two-party vote fell from 49.9 per cent to 43.6 per cent.

That fall of 6.3 points is smaller than the national swing of 10.3 points, and Mr. DaBreo's ability to run ahead of his party's decline speaks to his standing in the parish. A seat lost by seven, however, required the NNP to move forward, not merely to fall back more slowly than elsewhere.

AN INCUMBENT WHO USED HER TERM

Ms. James became one of the most visible members of the NDC government, serving as Minister for Climate Resilience, the Environment and Renewable Energy. She entered the 2026 campaign as a sitting minister with four years of constituency work behind her, defending a seat she had won by the narrowest margin in the country.

A seven-vote majority is a warning to the winner as much as an opportunity for the loser, and Ms. James appears to have treated it as a warning: her vote grew by 324 in an election in which total turnout in St. John fell.

THE SPLIT WAS NOT THE REASON

St. John had four candidates in 2026. The DPM's Mr. Gill, an attorney, former CARICOM ambassador and the party's deputy leader, promised voters 'powerful' leadership and took 82 votes; the GULP took 24.

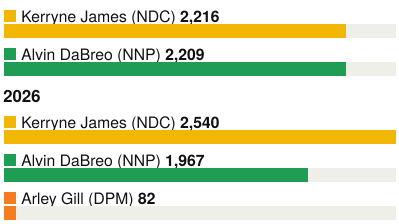
Even had every one of those 106 votes gone to the NNP, Mr. DaBreo would still have lost by 467. Unlike the Town of St. George, where the DPM's vote decided the seat, the third parties in St. John were a footnote. The NNP's problem here was its own vote, not a divided opposition.

GOUYAVE WENT ONE WAY

The polling-division returns show where the seat was decided. The NNP carried only 4 of the 21 divisions: Clozier, the Florida Medical

2022 VS 2026

Votes by candidate, in party colours



573 votes

NDC winning margin in 2026

BY THE NUMBERS

7 → 573

NDC margin in 2022 and in 2026, same two candidates

4 of 21

Polling divisions won by the NNP

–242

Fall in the NNP vote since 2022

287

Switchers the NNP needed to win

Station and two of the three Concord divisions, with its best results at around 59 per cent of the two-party vote in each.

The NDC won Gouyave and its surroundings clearly. At the St. John's Anglican School the NNP took 38.4 per cent across two divisions, and only 31.5 per cent in one of them; at the three St. John's R.C. School divisions it took 40.1 per cent; at Mount Granby, 34.9 per cent; and at Grand Roy, across four divisions, 40.8 per cent.

Florida was divided. The NNP won the Florida Medical Station by 107 votes to 75 but lost all three divisions at the Florida Government School, by 381 votes to 298 between them. That pattern, holding a small station while losing the larger school next door, recurs across the parish.

THE VOTERS WHO STAYED HOME

St. John's register grew by 824 names between 2022 and 2026, yet only 172 more ballots were cast. Turnout fell from 69.8 per cent to 64.2 per cent, and the number of registered voters who did not vote rose from 1,928 to 2,580.

Measured against the whole electorate, the NNP won the votes of 34.6 per cent of all registered voters in 2022 and 27.3 per cent in 2026, while Ms. James's share barely moved, from 34.7 to 35.2 per cent. The gap that decided the seat opened on the NNP's side, among people who had voted for the party before and did not do so again.

TWO HUNDRED AND EIGHTY-SEVEN VOTERS

To have won the seat, the NNP needed 287 voters to switch sides, or 574 more of its own supporters to turn out. The latter is about one in five of those who stayed home, and only a little more than double the 242 votes the party has lost since 2022.

St. John is not lost. It is a seat the NNP held in its hands four years ago and allowed to drift, and restoring the 2022 vote alone would cut the deficit by more than 40 per cent.

WHAT CAN BE DONE: A FOUR-YEAR PLAN FOR ST. JOHN

St. John needs the NNP to treat it as what it was in 2022: the most winnable seat in the country.

Year one, 2027: settle the candidate early. If Mr. DaBreo stands again, give him a funded office in Gouyave and a full-time organiser; if not, name a successor in public in 2027, not in 2030. Rebuild a household list from the 2022 NNP vote, which came within seven votes of victory.

Year two, 2028: make Gouyave the centre of the campaign. The town's fishing community, its vendors and young people, and the workers at the nutmeg station need to see the NNP every month, not every five years. Hold regular meetings and build a short local programme from what people say. Register new voters monthly, since the register grew by 824.

Year three, 2029: recruit a captain for each of the 21 polling divisions, with turnout targets based on the 2022 vote. Protect Clozier, Concord and the Florida Medical Station, and narrow the gap at the Florida Government School, Grand Roy and Mount Granby.

Year four, 2030: run the campaign as a turnout operation first. The target is 287 switchers or 574 new supporters, and the first step is simply to bring back the 242 NNP voters who did not support the party this time.

THE LESSON FOR EVERY NNP SEAT

A narrow defeat is an asset only if it is used. In 2022 St. John was lost by seven votes; in 2026 it was lost by 573. The candidate did not change. What changed was four years in which the sitting member worked her seat and the NNP failed to keep pace.

Every NNP seat lost narrowly in 2026, from St. Andrew South East to St. Mark, now faces the same choice. It is the four years after a close defeat that decide the next result, not the four weeks before polling day.

THE ARITHMETIC OF ST. JOHN

Measure	2022	2026	Change
NNP votes	2,209	1,967	−242
NDC votes	2,216	2,540	+324
Third-party votes	19	106	+87
NNP share of two-party vote	49.9%	43.6%	−6.3 pts
NNP two-party share nationally	48.0%	37.7%	−10.3 pts
Winning margin	NDC +7	NDC +573	
Registered voters	6,392	7,216	+824
Turnout	69.8%	64.2%	−5.6 pts
Registered voters who did not vote	1,928	2,580	+652
NNP votes as a share of all registered voters	34.6%	27.3%	−7.3 pts
Polling divisions won by the NNP		4 of 21	
Switchers the NNP needed to win		287	

Two-party figures exclude minor candidates (2022: GULP 19; 2026: DPM 82, GULP 24). 2026 figures are provisional results from the Parliamentary Elections Office, all 21 polling divisions verified.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR 2030/31

1. Use a narrow defeat: seven votes was the best start of any NNP seat.
2. Settle the candidate early and fund an office in Gouyave.
3. Win Gouyave: the town's divisions decided the seat.
4. A smaller-than-national swing is not enough in a seat lost by seven.
5. Do not blame the split: the DPM and GULP took only 106 votes.
6. Bring back the 242 NNP voters who did not vote for the party in 2026.
7. Captain all 21 divisions, with targets from the 2022 vote.
8. Target 287 switchers or 574 new supporters.

Sources: Parliamentary Elections Office live results, live.elections.gd (2026, provisional; polling divisions read 9 Nov 2026); Wikipedia (2022 general election); Wee FM (Arley Gill, DPM candidate, 2026); NOW Grenada (2022 nominations; 2026 results). Analytics computed by the author from the published counts. Analysis by Greg Hosten, Vol. 6 of a weekly constituency series. Written in the style of a newspaper report; not a publication of any news organisation.